



Same Balance, New Argument

Structured Handovers for a Babysitting Co-op's Point Ledger

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Background

Babysitting co-ops keep a running point ledger to make reciprocal childminding feel fair, but the ledger-keeper role itself changes hands every year or two. Little is known about what a new keeper actually inherits, or whether writing the handover down changes what gets disputed.

Aims

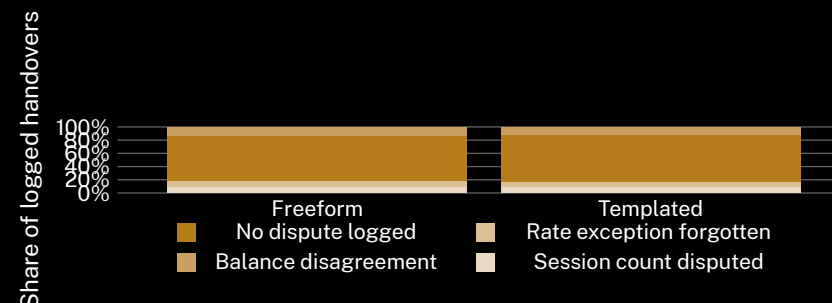
- Test whether a structured handover template reduces point-balance disputes after a ledger-keeper handover.
- Compare dispute rate and dispute type between templated and freeform handovers.
- Track whether informal side-arrangements survive the handover regardless of format.

Methods

- n = 41 babysitting co-ops recruited via parenting-network classifieds; one ledger-keeper handover each.
- Randomised assignment to a structured handover template or the outgoing keeper's own freeform explanation.
- 10-week post-handover window; disputes logged via fortnightly co-op survey; template fields pre-registered.

Results

Point-balance dispute rates did not differ meaningfully between templated and freeform handovers across the 10-week window. Side-arrangements carried forward at a comparable rate regardless of format.



Templated handovers logged a 29% dispute rate versus 31% for freeform across 41 co-ops (Mar–May 2026) — not distinguishable from chance.

Discussion & conclusions

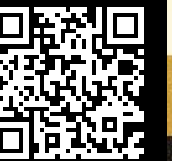
A template did not change what got disputed once the ledger changed hands. Side-arrangements travelled just as reliably either way — the friction sits in interpretation, not information transfer. Next: a witnessed handover, not a better-written one.

References

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De-identified ledger data only; no children named; consent obtained via each co-op's group chat.

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“The new keeper inherited the ledger.
The arguments started anyway.”

Dispute rates held steady across 41 co-ops whether the handover was templated or improvised, March–May 2026.